

CENTRAL AND SOUTH AMERICA



MONT PELÉE

On May 8, 1902, Mont Pelée, a volcano on the Caribbean island of Martinique, erupted. A stream of lava, gas, and hot dust poured down the mountain toward the port of St. Pierre, engulfing the town and killing 30,000 people. Volcanoes are a constant hazard in the Caribbean – two-thirds of Montserrat, including the capital Plymouth, became uninhabitable when the Soufrière Hills volcano erupted in 1995.



ISTHMIUS OF PANAMA

The Isthmus of Panama is a narrow strip of land that separates the Caribbean Sea in the Atlantic Ocean from the Gulf of Panama in the Pacific. It forms the land bridge linking Central America to South America. The Isthmus is only 30–130 miles (48–210 km) wide. Its narrow shape and strategic location made it the ideal choice as the site for the Panama Canal.